

Sony Ericsson P1i

Fixing old mistakes



The P1 is the latest in Sony Ericsson's business line, succeeding both the P990i and the M600i—bringing the former's functionality to the latter's form factor. Its dimensions are nearly the same as the M600i, adding a couple of millimetres to the thickness, and its style statement is in Chinese—the shiny plastic sides and the chrome details look downright tacky, and we prefer the M600i's matte finish. It's based on the same Symbian UIQ 3 platform as the P990i and M600i, with a few minor changes. The OS is definitely quicker, which is probably due to the oodles of program memory that the phone comes with—128 MB, doubling the M600i's 64. Other than that, there's nothing remarkably new here.

Just like the M600i, the phone doesn't feature any soft-keys, and you're expected to operate it using either the stylus or your fingers on the touchscreen. There's also the three-way jog dial, which thankfully does away with the annoying protrusion that featured on the previous phones. The screen itself is wonderfully vibrant and quite responsive to touch, but is naturally a fingerprint magnet. We recommend

slapping on a screen guard the second you open the box—the screen's responsiveness will suffer a tad, but it'll be worth it. The stylus is longer and easier to write with, and its locking mechanism seems much firmer than the M600i's flimsy setup. The QWERTY keypad is the same as the M600i—two letters to the key—and is just as easy to get used to.

The 3.2 megapixel camera is respectable, though not exceptional—indoor photos are a bit grainy, but overall, the clarity and colour balance of the photos satisfies. There's a second camera on the front for video calls, but you can't take self-portraits with it. Like the P990i, this model also comes with a business card scanner—just take a photo of a business card, and the OCR software will create a new contact for you. The feature works just as well (or as badly, as the case may be) as the one on the P990i.

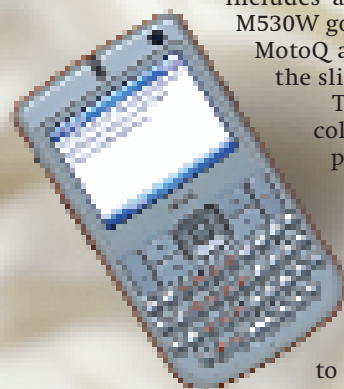
In the connectivity department, the P1i supports 3G (but no EDGE) and WiFi—802.11b, to be precise. WiFi connection speeds are quite decent, and battery life thankfully doesn't suffer for it.

The P1i isn't really light years ahead of the P990i, but it definitely nudges it off top spot. There's no annoying flip top, the audio levels are louder and the huge program memory lets you multi-task like you've never multi-tasked before.

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

ASUS M530w

Nokia's bane



The M530w is another entry level PDA phone from ASUS—it lacks a touchscreen, but includes a full QWERTY thumb board. The M530W goes head to head with the Motorola MotoQ and the Nokia E61i—right down to the slim design.

The ASUS M530w is offered in two colours—white and black. We got the pearly white for review, and the photographs don't do it justice—it may look like the old Sony Ericsson T100, but the white body with orange detailing manages to look quite appealing. The navigational buttons are well laid out—they are large, comfortable to use and have good tactile feedback. However, the numeric keys have an orange glow thanks to the backlight, and the screen-printed numbers on them are not easily legible.

The M530w runs on Windows Mobile 6 and has all the standard features set of the mobile OS. There is no ASUS launcher application pre-installed here.

You get the ClearVue viewer for Word, Excel, PPT and PDF file formats. Other applications include Java, Remote presenter, Task Manager and a business card recogniser.

The M530w's multimedia features—especially music—are just passable. It supports MP3 and video playback, but entry level phones from other makers will easily beat the M530w at this. The 2 megapixel camera is quite similar to one on the P256, and delivers decent photographs—nothing particularly remarkable here.

There numerous connectivity options—WiFi, 3G, GPRS and Bluetooth. Internet browsing speeds are decent on WiFi and GPRS, though the battery life takes a beating when these features are used. We managed around two days of battery life on nominal usage. We didn't encounter any problem with signal reception, but voice clarity could do with work—some crackles creep in.

At Rs 18,500, the M530w goes head to head with the Nokia E61i, which has a similar feature set. Given a choice between the two, choosing one is a tough call; we'd stay with Nokia E61i just for Symbian.

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

Blackberry Pearl 8120

Style++

The 8120 is the latest in Blackberry's Pearl series. Though venerable in the business domain, Blackberries were devoid of any consumer frills which other phones offered—thus the Pearl 8100 was born, but it came with some shortcomings. The 8120 improves on many aspects but one—3G—but that shouldn't matter in India anyway.

The 8120 is simply gorgeous—something you will fall in love with at first sight. The phone is slim, lightweight and feels superb to hold. Its dimensions are perfect—comfortable in the palm and the pocket. The 2.2-inch display may not be the best, but it is bright enough to get your work done. Properly aliased fonts are easy on the eyes and make the most out of this screen.

The 8120 makes do with a pseudo-QWERTY keypad—two letters per key, and text entry is predictive. It takes a while to get use to this format, but we got up and running on it within an hour. The roller ball (pearl) at the centre is used for navigating menus, pages, etc., and works like a charm. The unusual input method feels odd, but once you get used to it, going back to another format is boring.

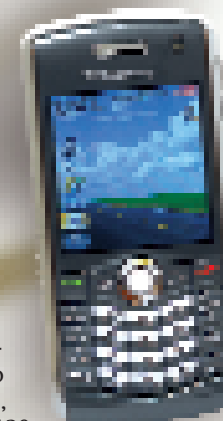
Business features are the forte of Blackberries, and that requires no introduction. The phone can easily handle most commonly used files types—DOC, XLS, PDF, etc. The PIM func-

tions are well implemented, and are quite easy to grasp.

The 8120 supports most music formats, and does a good job of playing them. It even plays MPEG4 video. The 3.5 mm jack lets you plug in better earphones if you want them. The jack is placed near the top edge, and will be uncomfortable when in your pocket. The phone comes with a paltry 64 MB of internal memory, but supports a hot-swappable microSD card. Blackberry hasn't been able to fix the basic issues with their cameras—photographs lack sharpness, and tonal accuracy suffers.

Internet browsing using WiFi was great; not so much with GPRS. The phone also supports Bluetooth and USB. When it comes to the core function of being a telephone, Blackberry outshines most and the Pearl 8120 is no exception. It has the best call reception in this entire test. During our test, the phone remained alive for four days before needing a recharge.

At Rs 25,000, the Pearl 8120 is an excellent business device with just one shortcoming—no 3G (high speed internet). If you are interested in this model for the multimedia capabilities, we'd advise you to look elsewhere.



RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

Apple iPhone

Bliss...

The iPod changed the way we listen to music, and the iPhone is bound to change the way we use a cell phone. It's not available in India yet, but we went ahead and bought one to give you a glimpse of this Next Best Thing.

The 320x480, 3.5-inch display dominates the entire length of the phone. The screen is sharp, crystal clear and has excellent colour reproduction. Watching videos is an amazing experience.

There is no keypad or QWERTY on this phone—hence the huge screen. You use a virtual keyboard—touch the letters to type them in. It's fun once you master it, but can be inaccurate if you use your thumbs.

The user interface is hard to describe in words—once you get used to the touch, using the phone becomes plain instinct. Getting around menus is fun; swipe your finger up or down to scroll any list, swipe it left or right to move left or right. The single button is used for exiting all applications—as simple as it gets.

The iPhone also has all the features of the iPod. Music quality is good, but the iPod sounds better. The bundled earphones are rubbish as usual—no bass, no

highs, just mids. The headphone jack is recessed, and all earphones don't fit it directly—they need an adapter, curse Apple. Video playback is simply the best we have seen on any portable media player. Viewing photographs is fun, and you can use your fingers to zoom in and out—very natural.

Safari does a great job of rendering non-optimised Web pages—more so if you rotate the phone to view sites in landscape mode. To read, you can zoom in and out on any part of the page. The phone is completely locked and installing additional applications requires hacking the phone; we don't recommend this.

To conclude, this is the best phone we have reviewed, period. It'll be wise to wait for the iPhone's official release in mid-2008, though.



RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★